February 4, 2026

Hiring Committee
Economic Studies Program
The Brookings Institution
Washington, DC

Dear Hiring Committee,

Brookings has long represented the kind of economic research I want to be doing: work that is empirically serious, policy-oriented, and written with the explicit aim of informing real decisions rather than living only within academic debates. The Economic Studies Program's emphasis on rigorous analysis paired with clear public communication aligns closely with how I think about the purpose of applied economics, and it is the primary reason I am excited to apply for the Research Assistant position with the Retirement Security Project.

I am an empirically minded researcher-in-training motivated by careful data work that helps clarify tradeoffs, quantify impacts, and move policy conversations forward. My interests sit at the intersection of labor and public economics, applied econometrics, and policy-relevant industrial organization—areas where institutional detail, identification choices, and thoughtful interpretation meaningfully shape conclusions. What draws me to Brookings is not only technical rigor, but the expectation that research be legible, useful, and responsive to real policy contexts.

The Retirement Security Project, in particular, sharpened my interest in this role. Its focus on aging, health risk, and long-term economic security highlights how deeply policy outcomes depend on heterogeneous lived realities. Questions around retirement adequacy, long-term care, and fiscal sustainability are shaped by work histories, health shocks, family structures, and unequal access to financial buffers. I am especially interested in research that disaggregates these experiences rather than flattening them—work that gives names and magnitudes to outcomes often discussed only in aggregate.

This perspective is personal but not sentimental. As a first-generation college student from an immigrant family, I have seen how retirement planning frequently reflects constrained tradeoffs rather than idealized financial optimization: investing in children's education, absorbing economic shocks, and relying on home equity—if it exists—or intergenerational support in place of formal retirement systems. This experience does not replace rigorous analysis, but it informs the questions I find most urgent and the care with which I approach empirical work intended to guide policy affecting families like mine.

I am at a pivotal point in my career, actively defining my research identity. I have had exposure to private-sector empirical work, academic research, and limited government-adjacent settings, but I am intentionally seeking a think-tank environment where research is explicitly designed to inform public understanding and policymaking. Brookings—and Economic Studies in particular—offers a setting where technical rigor, institutional knowledge, and public relevance coexist. I see this role as an opportunity to learn deeply, contribute meaningfully, and help produce research that is careful, grounded, and genuinely informative.

Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how I could contribute to the Retirement Security Project and the Economic Studies Program.

Sincerely,

Alejandro De La Torre

Alejandro De La Torre

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Education

University of Wisconsin–Madison Expected May 2026
B.A. Economics (Mathematical Emphasis) and Information Science (Analytics)
Certificate in Mathematics
Cumulative GPA: 3.347/4.000

Relevant Coursework: Real Analysis, Probability Theory, Causal Inference, Econometrics, Mathematical Statistics, Linear Algebra, Multivariable Calculus

IES Abroad – Barcelona: Liberal Arts & Business Spring 2025
Host Institutions: Universitat Ramon Llull (Blanquerna), Universitat Pompeu Fabra
Relevant Coursework: Research Techniques and Statistics, International Finance, Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning in Business

Howard University Summer 2024
American Economic Association Summer Program
GPA: 4.000/4.000
Relevant Coursework: Microeconomic Theory, Mathematical Economics, Econometrics I

Research Experience

Research Assistant, Professor Alice Wu Sep 2025–Present
University of Wisconsin–Madison Department of Economics

- Support ongoing revisions to job market papers on employer learning and the academia–industry race for AI researchers.
- Collect, clean, and link large-scale publication and patent data (>800,000 computer science papers) using Python, REST APIs, and automated web scraping pipelines.
- Construct and validate matched publication–patent datasets, including author–inventor linkages, timing windows, and content-based similarity inputs for downstream modeling.
- Perform exploratory data analysis to assess match quality, coverage, and selection patterns across academia and industry.

Research Assistant, Professor Yaron Nili Oct 2022–May 2024
University of Wisconsin Law School

- Compiled and analyzed firm-level datasets on peer group designations for S&P 1500 companies (2005–2022), supporting multiple law review and working paper projects.
- Identified, classified, and coded proxy statement disclosures related to antitrust, ESG, cybersecurity, and director expertise.
- Contributed to research projects including *Specialist Directors* (SSRN), *Peer Group Governance*, and *Shadow Governance*, supporting early-stage data construction and literature review.
- Presented exploratory findings on antitrust-related board expertise at the 2023 UW Undergraduate Research Symposium.

Professional Experience

Analysis Group Washington, DC
Summer Analyst Intern June 2025–August 2025

- Supported defense in U.S. ITC Section 337 patent infringement litigation involving solar panel manufacturers; co-developed 40+ exhibits for expert rebuttal report, auditing opposing expert's calculations and identifying methodological flaws, double-counting, and data misclassification.
- Analyzed HR, payroll, and facility expenditure data to evaluate whether the complainant met the domestic industry requirement under Section 337; synthesized findings to challenge claims of substantial U.S. investment and demonstrate limited nexus to U.S. manufacturing activity.
- Conducted data scraping and analysis of 100+ patent litigation cases involving major smartphone manufacturers using LexisNexis, Excel, and Stata; currently designing intern capstone on the evolving role of behavioral economics in antitrust litigation.

Analysis Group Washington, DC
Summer Extern (AEA Summer Program) May 2024–July 2024

- Conducted a literature review examining competition in generic drug markets, trends in Medicare spending, historical M&A activity in the generic pharmaceutical industry, and relevant healthcare policy and antitrust legislation to inform research design.

- Designed and presented a case study analyzing the impact of horizontal mergers among U.S. generic pharmaceutical manufacturers on average spending per dosage unit of therapeutically equivalent drugs from 2012–2022.
- Collected, cleaned, and analyzed large-scale datasets using Python, R, and Stata, drawing on Refinitiv, CMS Medicare Part D Spending by Drug, and Bloomberg Terminal data to evaluate post-merger price effects.

Campus Leadership & Student Services Experience

UW–Madison Posse Program Madison, WI
Alumni Relations Intern Aug 2024–Present

- Develop and execute automated alumni communication campaigns using Eloqua and SQL-informed segmentation to re-engage 500+ alumni.
- Design cross-platform engagement strategies to strengthen mentorship pipelines, inter-cohort visibility, and alumni–student connections.
- Lead planning and execution of alumni events in collaboration with program leadership, supporting professional development and community-building.

Center for Pre-Law and Pre-Health Advising Madison, WI
Advising Intern Feb 2024–Dec 2024

- Served as primary point of contact for students and alumni, scheduling 30+ advising appointments weekly and managing high-volume email and phone inquiries.
- Supported diversity and inclusion initiatives through outreach at campus resource fairs and informational events.
- Contributed to development of a Pre-Law 101 Canvas course expanding access to advising resources for 3,000+ students and alumni.

Teaching and Educational Experience

Pomona College Academy for Youth Success (PAYS) Claremont, CA
Teaching Assistant Jun 2023–Aug 2023

- Mentored 18 rising high school juniors, providing academic support and college preparation in an intensive residential program.
- Taught a business elective incorporating applied workshops in professionalism and critical thinking.
- Facilitated academic assessment and feedback in coordination with faculty and program staff.

ClubZ! In-Home Tutoring Madison, WI
Private Tutor Jan 2024–Jul 2024

- Delivered one-on-one tutoring to a middle school student in core subjects and a high school freshman in AP Calculus AB, who earned a score of 4 on the exam.
- Emphasized conceptual understanding and pacing over rote problem-solving, supporting long-term retention and student confidence.
- Collaborated with parents, teachers, and ClubZ! staff to align tutoring with classroom expectations and academic goals.
- Integrated classroom feedback and assessment results to tailor lesson plans and monitor academic progress.

Honors and Awards

Posse Foundation Full-Tuition Leadership Scholarship 2022–Present
Hispanic Scholarship Fund Scholar 2023
NIRCA Cross Country National Championships, 2nd Place (Men's Championship) 2023

Skills

Programming & Data: Python, R, Stata, SQL
Tools: LaTeX, Git/GitHub, Bloomberg, Refinitiv, LexisNexis, Tableau
Languages: Spanish (Native; State of California bilingual certification), English (Fluent), Catalan (Basic)